POSTDOCTORAL RESEARCHER ADVISING STATEMENT

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Purpose

I am providing you with this statement of advising philosophy to enhance communication and transparency in our working relationship. It is intended to supplement our ongoing interactions and informal discussions and not to stand as a set of rigid requirements. My goal is that you can use this document to help guide you during your time in the SEFS lab. I view our professional relationship as a collaboration, with my role as your advisor to provide you with opportunities to develop your skill set, further establish your research interests, and establish new collaborations that help you to achieve your ultimate career objectives. As in all aspects of life, I recognize that each individual will vary in their backgrounds, aspirations, interests, progress, and accomplishments. In your first week, we will talk through this document together to establish expectations, discuss each other's goals for the project/collaboration, and adjust the document in order to put you on the best path towards your short-term and long-term career objectives. This is a working document, and will be updated through feedback and accumulated experiences. Any and all feedback on the document is thoroughly appreciated!

Note: This statement was adapted from a statement of adviser philosophy distributed by Scott Lanyon, Gordon Legge, and Moin Syed (University of Minnesota). Further, material here was adapted from the Quantitative Ecology Lab groups at NC State led by Krishna Pacifici and Nathan Hostetter. The statement incorporates philosophies discussed in the Mentoring Matters Faculty Training Program at NC State University in February 2025.

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Guiding Philosophy and Career Paths

As an advisor, my job is to help my postdoctoral advisees achieve short-term and long-term career objectives. As a postdoc, you are already well on your way to finding a long-term position. You may be entering this position with knowledge of exactly what type of position you want, or you may have a few different career paths you are potentially interested in. In order for me to be the best advisor I can be, I need to know early on what your career objectives are and what you want to get out of this postdoctoral training experience. Of course, those objectives may change during the duration of our time working together, which is completely okay! Discussions about your career plans and objectives can always happen during both formal and informal conversations that we have.

My advising style is “adaptive” in the sense that I strive to adapt my mentoring style to meet the needs and desires of each individual mentee. A common theme of my advising philosophy is a foundation of strong communication. Establishing an open and honest communication at the onset can go a long way towards an effective collaboration. We will discuss your objectives for the position during your first week and I will use that information to guide my advising style. If you ever have any concerns regarding my advising philosophy, please let me know! As academics, we are constantly trying to learn, and I certainly value any feedback that can help me to become a more effective advisor.

Lab Culture

The SEFS lab works in a collaborative and open science environment. We rely on trust and respect to build effective partnerships. We strive to improve and expand our skill sets through research, education, learning, and sharing knowledge.

- The lab is meant to be a safe and welcoming place. We strive to provide a supportive environment for all people, regardless of their background and identity.
- We ask one another for help when needed and we help each other when we can.
- We strive to be active listeners, approach discussions with an open mind, and listen with the intent to understand.
- We acknowledge our mistakes and try our best to learn from them.
- We continue to grow and change. We are always learning and looking for better ways of doing our work and accept constructive criticism with the goal of improving.

Time Requirements and Time Management

As a postdoc, I generally expect you to have a solid understanding of how you are able to best manage your time. You will be working on multiple research projects, collaborating with different individuals both at NC State and outside of the university, and will assist me in mentoring graduate students and/or undergraduate students in the lab. This will involve effectively apportioning time to your different responsibilities.

Unless otherwise described in your offer letter, you will be expected to work 40 hours per week. As you will see throughout this document, I expect a fair amount of you as a postdoctoral research in the SEFS lab. I will not be tracking how many hours you work, but rather will assess your performance based on your progress towards meeting short-term and long-term objectives. Depending on how projects progress and your specific job requirements, this may require some weeks working more than 40 hours and others working less than 40 hours. This all depends completely on how you most efficiently work towards achieving different tasks.

I do not have any strict requirements as far as mandating you to work all 40 hours in the office on campus. You are more than welcome to work some days (or parts of days) remotely if you would prefer doing so, and I of course understand that life scenarios often make it much easier to work from home. That of course is one of the beauties of quantitative work. However, I do typically expect you to be working in your office on campus at least 3 days per week, particularly

during the school year when graduate and undergraduate students are on campus. I also highly recommend meetings with other NC State faculty, staff, and/or students are done in-person if at all possible, unless there are specific reasons that it needs to be on Zoom.

Personal Life and Work-Life Balance

Work-life balance is essential!! While I ask a lot out of you, I do not want you to interpret that as meaning that I want you to constantly work. Rather, if you are feeling burned out, overwhelmed at work, or behind on goals that we have set together, I would highly prefer having a discussion on how we can resolve the problem as opposed to you working extremely long days and getting increasingly stressed. I expect all my advisees to have a personal life outside of the lab and to ensure that they find a fruitful and healthy balance between personal and work life. Raleigh is too awesome of a place to not have a life outside of the office!

It is important to remember that each person's approach to achieving a work-life balance will be different and depends on the large variety of life activities that we all have. I strongly recommend establishing a schedule for when you work and trying to stick to that schedule as much as possible. The nature of research is such that there is always more that can be done. That concept, while exciting and one of the many, many things I love about research, can also lead to very stressful situations if you don't establish boundaries between work and personal life. Having set times of the day and week when you do work versus when you don't work is crucial.

Conduct

Diversity and Respect of Others

The SEFS Lab values and respects all forms of diversity with respect to race/ethnicity, socioeconomic status, gender, sexuality, immigrant generation status, nationality, religion, and worldview, among other dimensions. Raleigh and the broader Research Triangle area are very culturally diverse locations, which provides an outstanding opportunity to learn about cultures you may not be familiar with. I expect all lab members to respect other forms of diversity and to continuously reflect on how our backgrounds, perspectives, and previous experiences shape the viewpoints that we have today. As an advisor, I strive to understand and respect your positions and how they inform your work. All lab members are required to show respect to others in the SEFS Lab, FER, and NC State community.

Relationships with other advisees. As a postdoc, I expect you to take a leadership role in the lab in terms of mentoring graduate and/or undergraduate students. In your first week, we will discuss students that are in the lab and how you may help advise them. In general, I will strive to have you serve as a more formal co-mentor with me for at least one student research paper, such that you will gain experience advising the student while also being recognized as a co-author on the resulting manuscript. At the same time, I encourage you to seek advice from other postdocs or students in the lab. The SEFS Lab will be most successful when there is a friendly

and collaborative environment among all students and postdocs. It is crucial that the relationships are supportive and not competitive. I generally am a firm believer in collaboration, and so if you feel that any advising/mentoring you are providing to students is worthy of a formal co-authorship, please communicate that with me and we can have a discussion about it.

***Ethics*.** All members of the SEFS Lab should familiarize themselves with, and abide by, the following code of conducts:

- North Carolina State University's Student Code of Conduct.
- NC State's General Code of Conduct and Ethics.

If you believe someone has violated the Code of Conduct or has displayed inappropriate or discriminatory behavior to others in the lab, please report it to me and I will take the appropriate action to address the situation. If the incident involves me, or for whatever reason you are uncomfortable reporting the incident to me, please contact Dr. Erin Sills, Department Head, FER (my supervisor).

Resolving conflicts. Communication is key to minimizing conflicts. For example, this document is an effort to clearly communicate my expectations to reduce the possibility of misunderstandings between my advisees and me. One of my primary goals for each of my advisee relationships is to have open and strong communication between both parties of the collaboration. If you have concerns about your interaction with me or with anyone else in the SEFS Lab, please don't hesitate to come talk with me. If you are uncomfortable speaking with me about your concern, please consult the Department Chair (Dr. Erin Sills) or Associate Department Chair (Dr. Chris Moorman) or the Department HR Liason (Colin Stepien). If you wish a conversation to remain anonymous, be sure to indicate that at the start of the conversation.

Meetings and Consultation

Lab Group Meetings. Lab meetings will generally take place each week during the fall and spring semesters. I will adjust the time of the meetings to align with all current lab members' schedules. Meetings will also take place during the summer, but the schedule will likely be more intermittent. Summer meetings may take place at more fun locations with cold beverages, good food, and outdoor seating. Lab meetings are in person and I expect all lab members to come to each meeting, or inform me if they are unable to make the meeting for a given week.

FER Department Seminar. Having a strong department community is very important for making the work environment more positive, and is something I feel quite strongly about. To help foster department community, I encourage all students and postdocs in the SEFS lab to attend the weekly FER Department Seminars. I try to attend the seminars as much as my schedule allows. These seminars highlight the breadth of environmental research across NC State. Plus, there's usually free snacks :)

Individual Meetings. I expect my advisees to schedule individual 1 hour weekly meetings with me and to schedule additional ad-hoc meetings as necessary. There is no specific agenda

required for these meetings, rather they serve as a mutual check-in about progress on projects and life in general. However, you should come to each meeting with a clear idea of the agenda or goals of the meeting.

Time Requirements. I will always do my best to provide timely feedback on publications, presentations, and other projects you do as part of your job duties. Below are a set of general guidelines to follow when seeking my feedback on something. These are the maximum time limits I will take to respond to you (unless I am out of the office, teaching a field course, or if there is some extraordinary life circumstance). I of course understand that there are exceptional circumstances when you may need feedback on something in a shorter amount of time. If you communicate with me regarding why you need a faster turnaround then the dates given below, then I will likely be understanding. However, if you continuously are seeking feedback on shorter timelines than outlined below, we will have a discussion to make clear our expectations are aligned. I generally plan out my weeks on Sunday, so if you get something to me at the end of the week, there is a good chance I'll put it on my todo list for the following week.

- Review of a full manuscript draft: 2 weeks
- Review of one or two sections of a manuscript: 1 week
- Presentation: 1 week (also ensure that we discuss the presentation in person before you present)
- Letter of Recommendation: 3 weeks
- Coding/analysis help: 1 week

Communication. I use three primary forms of communication: email, text, phone calls. I will give you my personal phone number. For larger work-related questions, I typically prefer that you send me an email. You can generally expect me to respond to an email from you within 24 hours (or on a Monday if you send it to me late on Friday). My approach to email is that I will strive to respond to you as quick as I can. If the email is just a quick question or request for a meeting, then we can take care of that quickly. If the email is asking for me to review something, then I will respond quickly to acknowledge I received your message and then respond later with the review within the time span described above. For a quick question or if communicating regarding field work, text messages or phone calls work great. I am fine with you texting/emailing me outside of work hours (since we all may work at different times).

I will strive to help you find the resources you need, but I also recognize that I may not always be the best resource. In such instances, you may want to find assistance outside the lab, whether it be a question related to your research or a more personal issue (e.g., difficulty with work-life balance, conflict with another lab member). A few resources that may be helpful in these situations include:

- NCSU Counseling Center (https://counseling.dasa.ncsu.edu/)
- Dr. Erin Sills, Department Head, FER
- Colin Stepien, FER HR Liason

Most days I work from campus in my office (Jordan 3115), usually somewhere around the hours of 9am-4pm. I typically work a bit in the morning and evenings as well during which I may respond to emails. Whenever my door is open, please feel free to come in to ask a research question, get some coffee, or have an ad-hoc meeting. If I'm in the middle of something then I'll let you know, but please don't hesitate to stop in and ask. If my door is closed, that almost always means I'm not there, am in a zoom meeting, or am focusing on something, so I won't be available to talk. I will occasionally work from home on days that I don't have to teach, in which case email/text will be the quickest way to reach me.

Independence

As a postdoc, I expect you to conduct and lead independent research projects. I view our working relationship as a collaboration. I will certainly work together with you on projects and help you as needed, but I expect you to have a fairly large amount of independence in accomplishing the research agenda. It is your responsibility to know the requirements of your research project, the funding source, and important deadlines for deliverables (e.g., reports, presentations, meetings, publications). Depending on where your funding source is coming from, you may have substantial flexibility in determining your own research projects, or the projects may be set in stone. This is something we will discuss during your first week on the project.

Publications and Authorship

Publishing high-quality research papers is typically the key product I will expect from postdocs in the SEFS Lab. The specific expectations will vary from project to project, but I will generally expect you to lead 2 publications for each year of a postdoc. This is highly variable and will depend on the specific scope of your project and the nature of the given publication, but this is rather just a general guideline. By the time you complete the postdoc position with me, these papers may very well not be completed or will be somewhere in the publication pipeline. If the project is not completely published and your are comfortable handing off the publication to someone else to take the lead, then we will discuss that before you leave for your new position. If the manuscript is somewhere in the publication pipeline, I expect you to continue to work on the project as needed in order to get it to be completely published. Of course, I understand that future jobs will take priority over this and will certainly be happy to push those towards the finish line in whatever way I can. I will also likely have you take some form of leadership role mentoring an undergraduate and/or graduate student in the lab in which you will be a co-author on the manuscript. I am also involved in a variety of collaborations, and so I will do my best to involve you in other research projects where I feel you could contribute and would be of interest to you and your career objectives.

Authorship. As with most things in the lab, early communication is essential for determining authorship arrangements! If you ever have a question regarding authorship for yourself or someone who assisted you on a project, please discuss these concerns with me and we can determine a good plan of action. On your primary projects, you will generally be the first author and I will be last author. I expect you to serve as the corresponding author on all manuscript

submissions. These authorship roles can be changed at a later date if we discuss them and mutually agree upon them. Usually, the first author has played the lead role in the project execution and will take the lead in writing the manuscript and overseeing the revision process. I expect the first author to retain primary responsibility for the publication process even if they leave the lab to take a position elsewhere. The same general procedure applies to authorship for conference presentations as well.

In general, the SEFS Lab will follow APA Guidelines for publications: “Authorship credit should reflect the individual’s contribution to the study. An author is considered anyone involved with initial research design, data collection and analysis, manuscript drafting, and final approval. However, the following do not necessarily qualify for authorship: providing funding or resources, mentorship, or contributing research but not helping with the publication itself. The primary author assumes responsibility for the publication, making sure that the data are accurate, that all deserving authors have been credited, that all authors have given their approval to the final draft; and handles responses to inquiries after the manuscript is published.”

Expectations as first author: The primary author assumes responsibility for the publication/report, making sure that the data are accurate, methods are described correctly, results are repeatable (e.g., scripts are functional, models converge), and cited literature is appropriate and understood. Additionally, the lead author is responsible for verifying the manuscript meets journal requirements prior to submission (e.g., text length, figure requirements, supplemental files, etc.)

Old, unpublished projects: When projects require significant lab resources (e.g., time, money, labor), lab members are given 3 years after graduation or moving on to another position to publish the work. After that time, I reserve the right to re-assign the project as needed to expedite publication. We always want the transfer of data and projects to be a coordinated, agreed upon step (e.g, post-doc started a new job, no longer has the time to be lead author, but can assist as co-author), but recognize this is not always the situation.

Professional Meetings. You will have opportunities to present your research in both formal and informal settings.

Below are some presentation expectations:

- As lead author, you are responsible for developing the presentation.
- Formal presentations will be shared with co-authors prior to the presentation.
- You must coordinate with me as some funding agencies also have strict requirements about reviewing public presentations (e.g., 2-week review period prior to presentation).

Developing a professional network is essential, regardless of your career objectives, and so I strive to provide you with different networking opportunities both around the Research Triangle as well as at professional meetings and conferences. Typically, I can support your attendance and presentation at one scientific conference per year to present your research. However, the availability of funds for travel depends on numerous factors (e.g., what grant your funded on,

where the conference is). There are also often small travel grants available at NC State that can assist in funding a conference trip. We should discuss what conferences are of interest to determine the best plan of action given your research and career objectives.

Funding: We will discuss the funding that is paying you for your position during your first week to make sure we both understand the expectations that we have for one another. Given there is mutual interest, I will strive to obtain more funding for postdocs for as long as I can until they find an alternative postdoc elsewhere or a permanent position. Of course, this all depends on the availability of funding and whether your interests align with the funding I can secure. I will also work with you on fellowship proposals that may be applicable for the types of projects you are interested in.

Teaching: Teaching requirements will vary across the specific details of the postdoc. If you have teaching requirements as part of your position, this should be clearly outlined in your offer letter, or some other official documentation from NC State. If it is not and you believe you have teaching responsibilities, please discuss this with me as soon as possible.

Data Management: Data Management is crucial to a successful project. Per NCSU regulations, data collected as part of funded research projects and/or as part of official duties are owned by the University, State, or funding agency and must be maintained and available during and after the project. This includes the data and metadata to describe and interpret data file fields.

Data back-up: You are responsible for backing up your data and metadata files. Options include an external hard drive or cloud options (e.g., Github, google drive). Data must be stored in a minimum of two locations (e.g., your desktop/laptop hard drive and a separate google drive). We recommend backing up your work once a day or at minimum once a week.

Data archival: Upon completion of your project, you must archive all data, metadata, and scripts so that results from your work are reproducible. Archives can include the lab Github or a similar online repository (e.g., Zenodo, ScienceBase).

Reproducible research: You must upload minimally sufficient data and scripts associated with reports and publications to the lab Github. Files must be well commented, include metadata files, and be able to reproduce the results in the report or publication. Prior to final upload, you must have another lab mate review and run the files to verify they are functional. Take a look at this manuscript for some good guidelines to follow regarding functional and reproducible research.

Data lifecycle:

1. All data (raw and modified) should be backed up (see above) along with local copies (stored on your hard drive).
2. All data cleaning, processing, quality control should be documented including necessary scripts and steps used.
3. All analyses should be clearly documented and all scripts and steps should be included and archived.
4. All final products (steps 1-3) should be uploaded and included on the lab Github page.

Summary of My Expectations for Postdocs:

You will:

- strive to maintain a high level of professionalism during work activities.
- independently lead the research associated with your project. This includes knowing the requirements of your research project, funding source, and important deadlines for deliverables (e.g., reports, presentations, meetings, publications).
- ask me or the appropriate contact for clarifications on anything that is unclear.
- attend lab meetings. If you cannot attend, you must inform me.
- schedule a 1 hour weekly meeting with me.
- come prepared to meetings, which includes a clear idea of the agenda or goals for the meeting.
- attend the FER department seminar series.
- keep meeting notes and track of your research progress.
- keep me informed of your research progress and timelines.
- keep your collaborators informed about your research and progress.
- critically review my comments on your drafts (not simply “accept all”) and ask questions if a suggestion is unclear or does not seem justified/appropriate.
- ensure that your research data are backed up and final products are reproducible.
- strive to improve and grow in your career interests.